JUGGLiN

For Three Players

A standard-deck Tarock game for three,
where every tarock has a twin and the Pagat beats the Fool

Designed by Jonathan Ratschat

45–60 minutes • Version 3.2 • 8 November 2026

Concept

Jugglin is a point-trick game for three with a standard deck of 52 cards and its two Jokers. The Jokers, the Aces, and the 2s to 5s are the **tarocks**, which are permanent trumps.

Players bid on how many talon cards they want. The fewer cards, the higher the bid. The auction winner becomes the **Declarer** and plays alone against the other two players, the **Defenders**. In a **Point game**, the Declarer needs 41 of the 80 card points. In **Tightrope**, they may win at most one trick. If nobody bids, everyone plays **Ramsch** alone.

The deck holds two Fools, two Monds, and two Pagats, the Honours of the game. A Pagat, normally the lowest tarock, beats a Fool whenever they meet in a trick. This is the **Juggler's Trick**.

Every deal is played for chips. In a Point game, certain **moments** also pay immediately to the winner of a trick, such as a King meeting its Queen or one Honour capturing another. After three rounds, the player with the most chips wins.

Setup

Players: 3.

Cards: A standard deck of 52 cards and its two Jokers, 54 cards in all. The Jokers, the Aces, and the 2s to 5s are the 22 tarocks. The other 32 cards are the suit cards.

Chips: All payments in these rules are counted in chips. The best way to play is with poker chips or tokens worth 1 and 5, about 200 chips' worth in total. Each player starts with **50 chips**. All other chips stay in the box as the **bank**. Without poker chips, keep score on paper (see Keeping Score).

Board: Optional. It lies in the middle of the table as a play aid. A coin on it marks the contract: the bid and game type in one cell.

Direction: Dealing, bidding, and play go clockwise.

Dealer: Choose the first dealer at random. After each deal, the player to the dealer's left deals next.

Forehand: The player to the dealer's left. Forehand bids first and leads the first trick.

Match: A match is **3 rounds**. In each round, every player deals once, so a match has 9 deals.

A Deal at a Glance

Each deal follows these steps. The sections below explain each one.

1. **Deal:** 6 cards face down as the talon, then 16 cards to each player.
2. **Auction:** Forehand first. Bid higher (Three, Two, One, Zero) or pass for good. If all pass, play Ramsch.
3. **Talon:** In Three, Two, or One, turn it face up. The Declarer takes a group and discards as many cards, tarocks face up. In Zero, it goes unseen to the Defenders. In Ramsch, it stays face down.
4. **Game type:** Point game, or after a bid of One or Zero also Tightrope (at most one trick).
5. **Tricks:** Forehand leads. In a Point game, pay the moments after each trick.
6. **Settling:** The Declarer settles the game with each Defender. In Ramsch, the player with the most card points pays.

Cards

Tarocks: The 22 tarocks are permanent trumps. From high to low, they rank:

1. The two Jokers, the **Fools**.
2. The two black Aces, the **Monds**.
3. The 5s, 4s, 3s, and 2s, by number. Between two cards of the same number, the black card beats the red one. For example, a red 5 beats a black 4, and a black 4 beats a red 4.
4. The two red Aces, the **Pagats**.

The black Aces play high and the red Aces play low. The Fools, the Monds, and the Pagats are the **Honours**.

Suits: Each suit has eight suit cards. From high to low, they rank King, Queen, Jack, 10, 9, 8, 7, 6. An Ace or a card from 2 to 5 is always a tarock, never a suit card.

Twins: Two tarocks of the same number and colour are twins, for example the two black Aces, or the 5 of clubs and the 5 of spades. The two Jokers are twins as well. Between twins in the same trick, the one played first ranks higher.

The Juggler's Trick: When a Fool and a Pagat are in the same trick, the Pagat wins it, whatever else is in the trick. With twin Pagats, the one played first wins. This is the only exception to the ranking. Against every other card, both rank as above.

Honour cycle: When an Honour wins a trick, it captures every other Honour in that trick. For example, the Pagat captures the Fool, the Fool captures the Mond, and the Mond captures the Pagat. A twin can also capture its twin. In a Point game, each capture pays (see Moments).

Card points: Table 1 lists the card points. Each trick won is worth 1 card point. Talon cards and discards count only the card points of their cards, never as a trick. A complete deal has 80 card points: 64 on the cards and 16 from the tricks.

Deal

The dealer shuffles, and the player to the dealer's right cuts. The dealer places the top **6 cards** face down as the **talon** without changing their order. Then the dealer deals packets of 8 cards, starting with Forehand, until each player has **16 cards**.

Table 1: Card points

Card	Card points
Honours: Fools, Monds, Pagats	4
King	4
Queen	3
Jack	2
10	1
Any other card	0
Each trick won	1
Total	80

Before the auction, a player who has no tarocks shows their hand, and the same dealer deals again.

Auction

Forehand speaks first, then the auction goes clockwise. On your turn, either bid higher than the current bid, or pass. The first bid can be any bid. Once you pass, you are out of the auction for this deal.

There are four bids, listed from lowest to highest in Table 2. The number tells how many talon cards the Declarer takes.

Table 2: Bids

Bid	Talon cards	Bid value
Three	3	2
Two	2	4
One	1	6
Zero	None	10

The auction ends when two players have passed and the third has bid. That player becomes the **Declarer** with their last bid. If all three players pass, play **Ramsch**.

Example: A is Forehand. A bids Three, B bids Two, and C passes. A bids One, and B passes. A is the Declarer with One.

Talon

In Three, Two, and One, turn the six talon cards face up without changing their order. They form consecutive groups: two groups of 3 in Three, three groups of 2 in Two, or six single cards in One.

The Declarer takes one group into their hand and then discards the same number of cards onto their trick pile. Kings and Honours may not be discarded. Discarded tarocks are placed face up, so every player sees them. Other discards go face down. The remaining talon cards go face down onto the Defenders' trick pile.

In **Zero**, the talon stays face down and goes straight to the Defenders' trick pile without being seen by anyone.

In **Ramsch**, the talon stays face down in the middle of the table until the winners of the first six tricks take its cards as gifts (see Ramsch).

Game Types

After the talon, the Declarer names one of two game types, listed in Table 3. Tightrope may only be named after a bid of One or Zero.

Point game: The Declarer wins with at least 41 card points.

Tightrope: The Declarer wins with at most one trick. As soon as they win a second trick, the game is lost and the deal ends. The negative rules apply (see Trick Play).

Table 3: Game types

Game type	The Declarer must	Game value
Point game	Take at least 41 card points.	Bid value + margin
Tightrope	Win at most one trick. Only after a bid of One or Zero.	Bid value + 2

Trick Play

First lead: Forehand leads the first trick in every game type and in Ramsch.

Following: Play goes clockwise. You must play a card of the led suit if you can. If you cannot, you must play a tarock if you can. If you can do neither, play any card. When a tarock is led, you must play a tarock if you can, and doing so counts as following suit.

Winning: The highest tarock wins the trick, but if the trick contains a Fool and a Pagat, the Pagat wins. Between twins, the one played first ranks higher. If the trick has no tarock, the highest card of the led suit wins. The winner leads the next trick.

Point game: There is no duty to beat the cards already played.

Negative rules: In Tightrope and Ramsch, two more rules apply to all players. A card **beats the trick so far** when it would win the trick if no more cards were played. A twin never beats its twin. Your **legal cards** are the cards that Following allows.

1. If one of your legal cards beats the trick so far, you must play such a card.
2. You may only play a Pagat when a Fool is in the trick and no Pagat is in it yet, or when all your legal cards are Pagats. This also applies when you lead.

Rule 2 keeps the Pagats back for catching a Fool. They cannot be used as a cheap trump or a safe low tarock.

Trick piles: The Declarer keeps one trick pile, and the Defenders share one. In Ramsch, everyone keeps their own.

Moments

Moments pay as soon as a trick is complete, before it is taken (Table 4). They apply only in Point games, never in Tightrope or Ramsch.

Opponents: Moments only pay between opponents, which are the Declarer and each Defender. Defenders never pay each other.

Who pays: The trick's winner collects every payment and never pays. The owner of the Queen, the King, the captured Honour, or a Pagat that loses the 16th trick pays, if they are an opponent of the winner. When a Pagat wins the 16th trick, the winner's opponents pay.

Calling: Before taking the trick, its winner calls out the moments in it, and the payers pay at once. Until the next card is led, any player may still call a missed moment.

Queen's Ransom: A trick contains a King and the Queen of the same suit. The Queen's owner pays the trick's winner **1 chip** as her ransom.

Fallen King: When you lead a King and another player wins the trick, you pay the trick's winner **1 chip**. Only a led King counts. A King played to someone else's lead never does.

Table 4: Moments

Moment	In a trick	Payment
Queen's Ransom	A King and the Queen of its suit.	The Queen's owner pays 1.
Fallen King	A led King, won by another player.	Its owner pays 1.
Honour Capture	An Honour captured by another Honour.	Its owner pays 2.
Pagat Ultimo	A Pagat in the 16th trick.	If it wins, opponents pay 2 in total. If it loses, its owner pays 2.

Honour Capture: When an Honour wins a trick, the owner of each other Honour in it pays the trick's winner **2 chips**. With three Honours in a trick, each captured Honour pays separately.

Pagat Ultimo: When a Pagat wins the **16th trick**, the winner's opponents pay **2 chips** in total, split evenly. A Defender collects 2 chips from the Declarer. The Declarer collects 1 chip from each Defender.

When a Pagat loses the 16th trick, its owner pays the trick's winner **2 chips**, if they are opponents. A Pagat still in hand is always played to the 16th trick, so keeping a Pagat to the end is always an attempt. This combines with Honour Capture. If a Mond captures a Pagat in the 16th trick, the Pagat's owner pays the winner 2 chips for each moment, 4 in total.

Example: Moments combine. B leads the King of hearts, C plays the Queen of hearts, and A, the Declarer, trumps with a black 3. B and C are Defenders. A collects 2 chips: B pays 1 for the Fallen King, and C pays 1 for the Queen's Ransom.

Example: B leads a black 5, C plays a Fool, and A, the Declarer, plays the other Fool. C's Fool was played first, so it wins and captures A's Fool. A pays C 2 chips.

Counting

In a Point game, count the Declarer's card points after the last trick: the card points of all cards in their trick pile, including their discards, plus 1 for each trick they won. The Defenders' card points are 80 minus the Declarer's total. The Declarer wins with 41 card points or more.

Tip: Count the smaller pile. Pull out the Honours, Kings, Queens, Jacks, and 10s, add up their card points, and add 1 for each trick. If it is the Defenders' pile, subtract the total from 80.

Settling

At the end of each deal, the Declarer settles with each Defender separately.

Game value: Start with the **bid value** (Table 2). In Tightrope, add 2. In a Point game, add the **margin** from Table 5: find the Declarer's card points in the row for a won or a lost game, and read the margin above.

Table 5: Margin

Margin	0	1	2	3	4
Won	41–46	47–52	53–58	59–64	65+
Lost	35–40	29–34	23–28	17–22	0–16

Payment: If the Declarer won the game, each Defender pays them the game value. If the Declarer lost, they pay the game value to each Defender.

Example: A plays Two as a Point game and takes 53 card points. The margin is 2, so the game value is 4 + 2 = 6. B and C each pay A 6 chips.

Ramsch

If all three players pass, everyone plays alone and tries to take as few card points as possible. The negative rules apply (see Trick Play), and Forehand leads.

Gifts: The winner of each of the first six tricks also takes the top card of the talon, shows it, and adds it to their trick pile. The gift has its normal card points but is not part of the trick.

Payment: Everyone counts their own card points, including 1 for each trick they won. The player with the most card points pays each other player **3 chips**. If two players tie for the most, each of them pays the third player **3 chips**.

Keeping Score

With poker chips: If you have to pay more chips than you have, borrow 10 chips from the bank, as often as you need. Note what you borrowed. If the bank runs out, note further loans on paper.

On paper: Write one column per player. Everyone starts at 0, and scores may go below 0. Each chip is one point on the score sheet. During the deal, note each moment payment, for example "A +1, B −1". After the deal, add the game payment and write each player's change for the deal in one row. Every row adds up to 0, which shows a mistake at once. Keep a running total for each player.

Match End

The match ends after 3 rounds. With poker chips, subtract any loans from your chip total. Totals may be below 0.

The player with the most chips wins. If players are tied, they share the win.

Design Notes and Credits

Jugglin is inspired by the Tarock games Slovenian Tarok, Königrufen, and Danish Grosstarock. I learned about them in Jerry Neill Furr's Tarocchi, written under the name Philebus. Further inspiration came from Skat, Doppelkopf, and Sean Ross's Beaver Tail.

Special thanks to all playtesters and everyone who helped improve Jugglin, especially Tanja Simic, Matthias Gilch, Bryce Carter, and freebird.

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A Deal at a Glance

1. **Deal:** 6 cards face down as the talon, then 16 cards to each player.
2. **Auction:** Forehand first. Bid higher (Three, Two, One, Zero) or pass for good. If all pass, play Ramsch.
3. **Talon:** In Three, Two, or One, turn it face up. The Declarer takes a group and discards as many cards, tarocks face up. In Zero, it goes unseen to the Defenders. In Ramsch, it stays face down.
4. **Game type:** Point game, or after a bid of One or Zero also Tightrope (at most one trick).
5. **Tricks:** Forehand leads. In a Point game, pay the moments after each trick.
6. **Settling:** The Declarer settles the game with each Defender. In Ramsch, the player with the most card points pays.

Cards

Tarocks: Jokers (Fools), black Aces (Monds), 5–2 by number, red Aces (Pagats). Same number: black beats red. A Pagat beats a Fool.
Twins: the same number and colour, or both Jokers. The first played ranks higher.
Honours: two Fools, two Monds, and two Pagats. An Honour that wins a trick captures every other Honour in it.
Suits: King, Queen, Jack, 10, 9, 8, 7, 6.

Card	Card points
Honours: Fools, Monds, Pagats	4
King	4
Queen	3
Jack	2
10	1
Any other card	0
Each trick won	1
Total	80

Auction

Bid higher or pass for good. If all pass, play Ramsch.

Bid	Talon cards	Bid value
Three	3	2
Two	2	4
One	1	6
Zero	None	10

Talon

Three, Two, One: Turn the talon face up, take a group, and discard as many. Never discard Kings or Honours. Discard tarocks face up.
Zero: The talon goes unseen to the Defenders.
Ramsch: The talon stays face down until the gifts are taken.

Game Types

Game type	The Declarer must	Game value
Point game	Take at least 41 card points.	Bid value + margin
Tightrope	Win at most one trick. Only after a bid of One or Zero.	Bid value + 2

In Tightrope, the game is lost and the deal ends as soon as the Declarer wins a second trick.

Trick Play

Follow suit. If you cannot, play a tarock. If you can do neither, play any card. A tarock played to a led tarock follows suit.

Negative rules (Tightrope, Ramsch): Beat the trick so far if you can. Play a Pagat only onto a Fool with no Pagat in the trick yet, or when all your legal cards are Pagats, also when leading.

Moments

Point games only. Paid to the trick's winner by its opponents. Defenders never pay each other.

Moment	In a trick	Payment
Queen's Ransom	A King and the Queen of its suit.	The Queen's owner pays 1.
Fallen King	A led King, won by another player.	Its owner pays 1.
Honour Capture	An Honour captured by another Honour.	Its owner pays 2.
Pagat Ultimo	A Pagat in the 16th trick.	If it wins, opponents pay 2 in total. If it loses, its owner pays 2.

Settling

Game value: The bid value, plus the margin in a Point game, or plus 2 in Tightrope.
Won: Each Defender pays the Declarer the game value. **Lost:** The Declarer pays it to each Defender.

Margin	0	1	2	3	4
Won	41–46	47–52	53–58	59–64	65+
Lost	35–40	29–34	23–28	17–22	0–16

Ramsch

Everyone plays alone, and Forehand leads. The winners of the first six tricks each take a talon card as a gift. The player with the most card points pays 3 to each other player. If two tie for the most, each of them pays the third 3.

Keeping Score

Poker chips: borrow 10 from the bank as often as needed. Subtract loans at match end.
Paper: one column per player, starting at 0. Every deal's row adds up to 0.

Match End

3 rounds, so 9 deals. The most chips wins.

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Game Board

Put a coin on the contract. Every payment goes directly from player to player.

Contract

Bid for talon cards, then name the game type.

Bid (talon cards taken)	Three 3 talon cards	Two 2 talon cards	One 1 talon card	Zero no talon cards
Point game 41 or more card points	2 + margin	4 + margin	6 + margin	10 + margin
Tightrope at most 1 trick, only after One or Zero	*not after Three or Two*		8	12
Ramsch if all pass	The player with the most card points pays **3** to each other player.			

Three, Two, One: take a talon group and discard as many, never Kings or Honours, tarocks face up.

Zero: the talon goes unseen to the Defenders.

Ramsch: the winners of the first six tricks each take the top talon card.

Cards and Tricks

Juggler's Trick
A Pagat wins every trick that holds a Fool.

Tarocks, high to low — **Honours:** Fools, Monds, Pagats

Joker (4)	A (4)	5	5	4	4	3	3	2	2	A (4)
★★	♠♣	♠♣	♥♦	♠♣	♥♦	♠♣	♥♦	♠♣	♥♦	♥♦
Fools	*Monds*									*Pagats*

Suit cards — ● card points

K (4)	Q (3)	J (2)	10 (1)	9	8	7	6

Each trick (1) — 16 tricks

Twins: the same number and colour, or both Jokers. The first played ranks higher.

Tricks: follow suit, else a tarock, else any card.

Negative rules (Tightrope, Ramsch): beat the trick so far if you can. Play a Pagat only onto a Fool with no Pagat in the trick yet, or when all your legal cards are Pagats, also when leading.

Moments

Point games only. Paid to the trick's winner by its opponents.

Queen's Ransom — 1
A King and the Queen of its suit. The Queen's owner pays.

Fallen King — 1
A led King, won by another player. Its owner pays.

Honour Capture — 2
An Honour captured by another Honour. Its owner pays.

Pagat Ultimo — 2
A Pagat in the 16th trick.
Wins: opponents pay 2 in total.
Loses: its owner pays.

Settling

80 card points: 64 on the cards, 16 for tricks. In a Point game, the Declarer needs **41**. Discards count as cards, never as tricks.

Margin by the Declarer's card points

Won	41–46 **0**	47–52 **1**	53–58 **2**	59–64 **3**	65+ **4**
Lost	35–40 **0**	29–34 **1**	23–28 **2**	17–22 **3**	0–16 **4**

Game value: the number in the contract cell, plus the margin in a Point game, settled with each Defender.

Out of chips: borrow 10 from the bank, and subtract it at match end. **No poker chips:** keep score on paper, where every deal adds up to 0.